

Confession and Grace

This is a review of a season, not a hunt for hidden sins. Write only what has already become clear. Nothing here is graded, collected or shown to anyone.

If the scrupulosity note applies to you, you may leave these pages blank and use a brief, familiar prayer instead.

1 • Check-in (gently)

1. What does Psalm 51:1 reveal about the mercy to which you are bringing this? Write it before you write anything else.

2. Has a repeated choice or relational pattern become clearer during the retreat? If so, name it. If nothing comes, do not manufacture it; "I do not see a pattern" is an acceptable answer. Move to the prayer.

3. Did that pattern involve actual wrongdoing, a human limitation, a health or trauma response, or some combination? Use the five questions below.

4. Who was affected, and what impact can you responsibly acknowledge?

The five questions

- ☐ What did I choose?
- ☐ Who was affected?
- ☐ What truth or responsibility did I knowingly avoid?
- ☐ Was this wrongdoing, a human limitation, a symptom, or some combination?
- ☐ Do I need confession, care, boundaries, treatment, repair, or more than one of these?

3 • Silence

Fifteen minutes, or the length you can manage. Anchor phrase: "According to your steadfast love."
Or: "Have mercy on me." Do not scan for sins; rest in the first verse of the psalm.

4 • Journal

1. What, if anything, surfaced during the silence? Write it plainly, without excuse and without exaggeration, and then apply the five questions to it.

2. David's consequences did not disappear when he was forgiven. Is there any repair, apology, or accountability that your confession points toward once you are home? Write what it is and who it involves. If it is serious in the way described in the boundaries card, write only the name of the qualified person you will consult.

3. Has concealment, defensiveness, or refusal to take responsibility affected your ability to love someone well? If so, how?

4. If I began living from the assurance of forgiveness while still accepting appropriate consequences, one possible change would be...

6 • Closing declaration

Read only what you can say honestly. Adjust the words if you need to.

God's steadfast love is revealed before my confession begins.

I have named what I can see, without exaggeration or excuse.

In Christ, forgiveness rests on God's faithfulness, not the intensity of my feelings.

I will accept both mercy and the faithful actions that accountability requires.

(Optional:) Forgiven much, I am free to love much.

5 • The confession card is written on an index card, not on these pages. Use general language; keep it safe. Writing and sealing are optional: you may simply read 1 John 1:9 and Psalm 103:12 aloud and finish there.